The length of cricket matches allows me plenty of time to notice things about myself. I realise, for example, how much I observe other people, trying to get a sense and feel for the right way to behave with them and, most importantly, whether I can trust them.

As I start playing in the Burnley third team, I am sharing a dressing room with lots of older people. I am quiet to begin with, just sitting there and watching and listening. But the great thing about being around adults, I find immediately, is that there is not the jostling and bullying, and desperation just to be accepted as part of a pack or a group that can come with teenagers. It simply just feels right. Everyone makes it clear that they have my back and are going to look after me if I need it. That is what this cricket team is about. It gives a swell of something purposeful, a cause to be optimistic about life. It is an unspoken rule that everyone looked after everyone else.

My close mates Gaz Halley and Dave Brown are both a year younger than me, and better cricketers. I meet them at 13 and, as would become a running theme with most of the closest people in my life, we don't initially really get on. They watch me running around after the ball and laugh at my sulking, kicking my cap back to fine leg when I'd bowled badly, but, for whatever reason, they take a shine to me. Out of the three of us, Gaz is the most confident. He helps Dave and me out of any social tangle, but neither of them had friends either at their school and, somewhere in our sub-conscious, we recognise that and form an unspoken, protective circle around each other. They are my interpersonal skills bodyguards, propping me up when I need it in any given social situation.

Anna and Nicole Mortimer are twins who come down to the club because their dad, Neil, plays for the club. The Mortimers' house is a safe place for us all to go and listen to records, to talk about cricket, to hang around. None of them go to my school, and I find a way to reinvent myself in the company of these people. I trust them and they have the confidence and social sparkle that I am struggling to find in myself. We are always at their place**.** I walk over to the Mortimers' in the early hours to watch the 1992 Cricket World Cup final between England and Pakistan. I am struck by the pain of England being bundled out in a hurry, but my eye is caught by the bowling of the Pakistani bowler Wasim Akram and the wild movement in the air his deliveries are able to conjure.